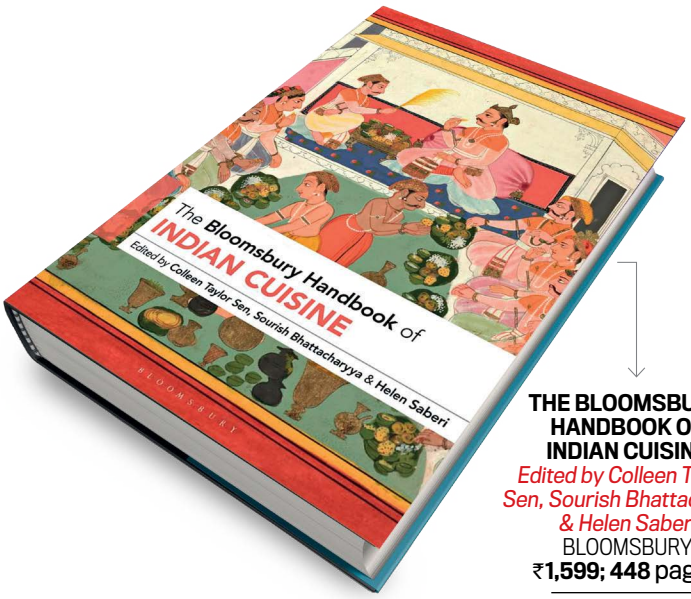
BOOKS

Culinary Tour de Force

FROM ESSENTIAL KITCHEN INGREDIENTS TO REGIONAL CUISINES, COOKING METHODS, PERSONALITIES AND A LOT MORE, ***THE BLOOMSBURY HANDBOOK OF INDIAN CUISINE*** IS THE MOST COMPREHENSIVE GUIDE TO INDIA'S RICH FOOD CULTURE



THE BLOOMSBURY HANDBOOK OF INDIAN CUISINE
Edited by Colleen Taylor Sen, Sourish Bhattacharya & Helen Saberi
BLOOMSBURY
₹1,599; 448 pages

The aroma of nigella seeds crackling in hot mustard oil wafted in from the kitchen as my cook prepared the tampering for masoor dal. Sitting at my work desk, leafing through *The Bloomsbury Handbook of Indian Cuisine*, it piqued my curiosity to know more about this essential spice in every Bengali kitchen. Glancing through the alphabetically arranged 'List of Entries', I found it indexed as Entry#175, Page 258. Nigella, as it turned out, is known by many misleading names such as *kala jeera*, black onion seeds or black sesame, which have no bearing on its origin or properties.

The short entry on nigella prompted me to check out the 'Spice Box' entry that detailed the Bengali five-spice mixture *panch phoron*, of which nigella is a key component. This nine-pager entry, in turn, took me on a deep dive of the incredible world of Indian spice mixes that vary not just from one state to another, but also from one household to the other—from the ubiquitous *garam masala* to popular *achari*, *tandoori* and *sambar* spice mixes to hyperlocal Mangalorean *meet mirsang* and Lucknow's *lazzat-e-tam*. 'Spice Box' has managed to summarise in one entry what easily warrants an entire book!

Therein lies the beauty and brilliance of this handy handbook—that it not only offers insight on your subject of interest, but also urges you to explore the staggeringly rich and diverse landscape of Indian cuisine. With over 260 entries on everything from kitchen ingredients to regional foods and cooking methods, to prominent personalities who've influenced India's culinary scene, this is the only book compiled of this scope since the late K.T. Achaya's comprehensive guide on

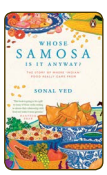
DESI PLATTER

⟶ Three books on the complex historical and contemporary nature of Indian food



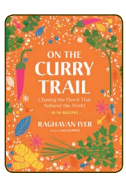
INDIAN ACCENT RESTAURANT COOKBOOK
by Manish Mehrotra
HACHETTE INDIA
₹1,899; 204 pages

When Indian Accent opened in 2009, Manish Mehrotra's pathbreaking approach to Indian food became an overnight sensation. In this new edition of the coffee table book, Indian Accent brings to its patrons the magic of its menu—with photographs by Rohit Chawla—to be recreated in home kitchens.



WHOSE SAMOSA IS IT ANYWAY? The Story of Where 'Indian' Food Really Came From
by Sonal Ved
PENGUIN VIKING
₹399; 256 pages

After the success of *Tiffin* comes Sonal Ved's new book that aims to trace how and what we eat today. The book discusses historical spice trading routes and ancient travel texts; the everchanging rules of vegetarianism; the delightful versatility and uniqueness of the Tagore kitchen, and much more.



ON THE CURRY TRAIL
Chasing the Flavor That Seduced the World
by Raghavan Iyer
WORKMAN PUBLISHING COMPANY
₹2,490; 208 pages